

Genuine Homes — Deployment Procedure

A brief, repeatable guide to deploy the full stack on free tiers.

Frontend → Vercel · Backend (API + PostgreSQL + Redis) → Render · Repo: github.com/Mundesdaniel/Genuine-Homes

Overview

The React frontend is hosted on **Vercel** and proxies `/api` and `/uploads` to the **NestJS API** on **Render** (configured in `vercel.json`). Both read the repo's `vercel.json` / `render.yaml`, so deployment is mostly connect-the-repo-and-go. End result: <https://genuine-homes.vercel.app>.

Step 1 — Backend on Render

1. Sign in at render.com with **GitHub**.
2. **New +** → **Blueprint** → select repo `Mundesdaniel/Genuine-Homes`. Render reads `render.yaml` and lists 3 resources (API, PostgreSQL, Redis).
3. Leave the `CORS_ORIGINS`, `PUBLIC_WEB_URL`, `PUBLIC_API_URL` fields **blank** for now, click **Deploy Blueprint**. First build ~5–8 min.
4. When `genuine-homes-api` is **Live**, copy its URL (`https://genuine-homes-api.onrender.com`).
5. Verify: open `<API>/api/health` → should return `{"status":"ok"}`.

Step 2 — Frontend on Vercel

1. Sign in at vercel.com with **GitHub** → **Add New...** → **Project** → import `Mundesdaniel/Genuine-Homes`.
2. **Critical settings** (Project → Settings → Build and Deployment):

Setting	Value
Root Directory	blank (repo root) — <u>not</u> <code>apps/api</code> or <code>apps/web</code>
Framework Preset	Other (not NestJS/Vite) — lets <code>vercel.json</code> control the build
Node.js Version	22.x
Build / Install / Output	leave as defaults — defined in <code>vercel.json</code>

3. **Deploy**. Build ~2–3 min. The production URL is <https://genuine-homes.vercel.app>.
4. Settings → **Deployment Protection** → turn **Vercel Authentication OFF** so the app is publicly viewable.

Step 3 — Connect the two & finish

1. In Render → `genuine-homes-api` → **Environment**, set and save:

Key	Value
<code>PUBLIC_API_URL</code>	<code>https://genuine-homes-api.onrender.com</code>
<code>PUBLIC_WEB_URL</code>	<code>https://genuine-homes.vercel.app</code>
<code>CORS_ORIGINS</code>	<code>https://genuine-homes.vercel.app</code>

2. **Load demo data:** Render → `genuine-homes-api` → **Shell** → run `pnpm db:seed` . Then log in with `admin@genuinehomes.ug` / `Password123!` .
3. From now on, every `git push` to `main` auto-deploys both services.

Gotchas encountered & fixes

Symptom	Cause	Fix
Render build fails: TS2307 Cannot find module './uploads/...'	The <code>.gitignore</code> rule <code>uploads/</code> (for runtime storage) also ignored the source folder <code>apps/api/src/uploads/</code> , so it was never pushed.	Anchor the ignore to runtime paths (<code>/apps/api/uploads/</code>) and commit the source module. (Commit <code>9953c05</code> .)
Vercel build fails; production URL 404	Project Root Directory was <code>apps/api</code> and framework <code>nextjs</code> — it built the <i>backend</i> as the website.	Set Root Directory to blank (repo root) and Framework to Other; redeploy.
Site shows "Login – Vercel"	Vercel Authentication (SSO protection) was enabled on all deployments.	Settings → Deployment Protection → disable Vercel Authentication.

Tip: because this is a pnpm monorepo, the Vercel **Root Directory must stay at the repo root** so the build can run `pnpm build:shared` before building the web app. Setting it to a sub-folder breaks the workspace build.

Live URLs

What	URL
App (share this)	https://genuine-homes.vercel.app
API base	<code>https://genuine-homes-api.onrender.com/api</code>
API health	<code>https://genuine-homes-api.onrender.com/api/health</code> → <code>{"status":"ok"}</code>

Free-tier notes: the Render API sleeps after ~15 min idle (first request then ~50s to wake); uploaded images are ephemeral; live chat/WebSockets are not proxied. · Generated 2026-10-09.